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Irit P. Erera
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ABSTRACT. This study introduces an instrument that operationalizes Kadushin's (1976; 1985) conceptualization of the administrative, educational and supportive functions in social work supervision. The proposed Supervisory Functions Inventory (SFI) was examined with 233 supervisors, employed in three types of social welfare agencies. Factor analysis generated seven factors corresponding to the three supervisory functions. A MANOVA procedure confirmed the ability of the SFI to distinguish between the supervisory groups. A further univariate analysis of variance revealed that the administrative function was responsible for this difference.

The purpose of the present study is to operationalize Kadushin's (1976; 1985) theoretical model of the administrative, educational, and supportive functions of social work supervision. There have been a number of attempts to set out a theoretical framework for social work supervision (e.g., Austin, 1981; Munson, 1983; Shulman, 1982). The choice of Kadushin's model in the present instance, however, was determined by the fact that this model has

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successfully taken into account most of the literature in the field, and is acknowledged by practitioners and academics alike as the most comprehensive conceptualization to date of social work supervision. The rich literature about supervision in social work, though considerable, includes few empirical studies. Moreover, such empirical studies as do exist have only a tangential bearing on the functions of social work supervision proposed by Kadushin (1976; 1985).

The main difficulty in connecting the results of previous studies with Kadushin's model relates to the fact that most studies did not examine all the supervisory functions. Further difficulties stem from the facts that these functions were not the focal point (see Kadushin, 1974; Munson, 1979; Poertner & Rapp, 1988); no explanation was offered with regard to the manner in which the examined items were selected, operationalized or validated (Eisikovits, Shurka & Baizerman, 1983; Kadushin, 1974; Munson, 1979; 1981); each research has operationalized the supervisory functions quite divergently (c.f., Eisikovits et al., 1983; Munson, 1979; Patti, 1977; Poertner & Rapp, 1983; Shulman, 1982); the empirical findings yielded inconclusive conclusions (see Eisikovits et al., 1983; Kadushin, 1974; Munson, 1981; Parsloe & Stevenson, 1978; Patti, 1977; Poertner & Rapp, 1983; Shulman, 1982; Wisconsin Department of Health and Social Services, 1977); and that different kinds of populations (i.e., supervisors, workers) were employed (c.f., Eisikovits et al., 1983; Kadushin, 1974; Munson, 1981; Poertner & Rapp, 1983; Shulman's, 1982). Finally, while most studies examined the actual time allotted to supervisory tasks, Poertner and Rapp (1983) examined the importance attributed to these tasks, while both Kadushin (1974) and Patti (1977) compared the actual and the ideal performances.

The upshot of the inconsistencies set out above is to make it almost impossible to compare the results of the different studies to one another and to the theory of supervisory functions. This state of affairs reflects the absence of a valid and agreed on instrument of measurement derived from a comprehensive theory of the supervisory role. The purpose of the present study, therefore, is to introduce and validate a Supervisory Functions Inventory (SFI) to measure the components of supervision in a diverse organizational

setting based on Kadushin's model. The SFI presented here would (a) allow a systematic study of supervision to be undertaken in a broad range of social services, and (b) help toward devising a standardized evaluation form for supervisors.

METHODOLOGY

Procedure

The research population comprised nearly all social work supervisors in Israel (certain agencies, such as the military, the prison service, and the governmental Mental Health Service, were excluded; these are secondary settings for social workers and their participation in the study presented special obstacles). They represented a wide variety of social welfare agencies, ranging from municipal welfare services to mental health centers. The data were collected by trained data collectors, who distributed anonymous self-administered questionnaires which they also collected after the questionnaires were completed. Supervisors who worked in remote areas of the country were sent the questionnaires by mail, together with stamped return envelopes. The questionnaires were completed by all ninety-nine supervisors working in municipal social welfare agencies and known to the Ministry of Welfare, and by 64% (134) of those working in other types of agencies.

The problem was how to distinguish supervisors who performed both the administrative and educational functions from those whose responsibilities were mainly educational. Following Austin's suggestion (1981) that organizations powerfully influence the behavior of the supervisors and the workers, we made an assumption that supervisors working in agencies with a service orientation (i.e., providing social services and carrying out eligibility decisions) performed more administrative tasks than those who work in agencies with treatment orientation (focusing on clinical treatment).

To ensure a valid classification of agencies according to their orientation (service vs. treatment), we invited professional judges to categorize these agencies. Forty-eight social work educators and social work supervisors, employed at various types of social wel-

fare agencies, scored each agency on a 10-point Likert scale, with 1 representing treatment orientation and 10 representing administrative or service orientation. The agencies were classified into three groups.

The first group of agencies, employing 99 supervisors (42.5% of the sample), were social service departments. The mean score of judges' responses for these agencies on the 10-point scale was 6.9. Supervisors in these departments performed middle management tasks and were formally acknowledged as "team leaders." We classified them as a separate group referred to as "team leaders."

The second group of agencies consisted of the National Department of Social Security and the Jewish Agency Department of Immigration and Absorption. The mean scores of the judges' responses for these two agencies were 6.6 and 6.9, respectively. We refer to the supervisors in these agencies ($N = 23$ supervisors, 9.9% of the sample) as "service-oriented supervisors."

The third group of agencies consisted of mental-health, rehabilitation and drug-treatment centers, probation offices, and general hospitals. The mean scores of the judges' response for each of these agencies were 2.6, 3.3, 4.6, 4.8, and 4.9, respectively. We refer to supervisors employed in these agencies ($N = 111$ supervisors, 47.6% of the sample) as "treatment-oriented supervisors." It should be noted that unlike the situation of comparable services in the United States, Israeli juvenile and adult probation services are units of the Ministry of Welfare; probation officers in Israel are trained social workers.

There were no significant differences in variables such as sex and age among the three groups of supervisors: 93% of the sample consisted of females, and the mean age was 42.8 ($SD = 7.0$). The three groups differed significantly with regard to professional education (Chi-Square = 44.9, $p < .001$, with Cramer's $V = .31$). All supervisors had an undergraduate degree in social work (BSW). However 42.9% (48) of the treatment-oriented supervisors and 30% (7) of the service-oriented supervisors also had MSW degrees. By contrast, only 16.2% (16) of the team leaders had MSW degrees. All team leaders had participated in a mandatory two-year training program which included courses in supervision, advanced intervention, administration, and team development. The vast majority

(97%) of service-oriented and treatment-oriented supervisors in this sample had also participated in supervision courses, although not as extensively as the team leaders.

Instrumentation

Supervisory functions. Task analysis seemed inappropriate to operationalize supervisory functions for two reasons. The first of these is that task analysis is a method applied to job analysis and aimed at defining jobs in accordance with the tasks performed in them (Fine & Wiley, 1971, p. 9). The method therefore relies primarily on what supervisors actually do (Poertner & Rapp, 1983), rather than on a comprehensive theory or conceptualization. Because supervisors have distinctive tasks in different agencies, generalizing about the supervisory role requires a unifying conceptualization that subsumes these tasks.

The second reason for not using the task analysis technique has to do with the definition of a task as "an action or action sequence grouped through time" (Fine & Wiley, 1971, p. 9). Accordingly, a task can include a number of actions (i.e., smaller job units), each belonging to a different function. Such tasks have been formulated by Poertner and Rapp (1983). So, for example, one of the tasks defined in their study was "listens and responds to staff concerning cases," which they listed as pertaining to the supportive function. Yet this task seems to address the educational function as well, since listening and responding to staff concerning their cases includes both the supportive action of talking with staff about their feelings toward clients and the task of discussing intervention plans with them; the latter can be regarded as both an educational and an administrative action.

We decided, therefore, to operationalize the three supervisory functions by means of action items. This process was executed in two stages. In the first stage we analyzed the literature pertaining to the three functions of the supervisory role as presented by Kadushin (1976; 1985), and identified action items. In the second stage, these action items were face-validated by independent judges, namely university faculty who teach supervision, and supervisors and managers in various welfare agencies. Following the suggestions of the judges, action items were eliminated, merged, or rephrased. The final Super-

visory Functions Inventory (SFI) contained 39 action items such as, "Applying policies to working plans" (an administrative action item), "Discussing assessment of clients with workers" (an educational action item), and "Assisting workers with handling their feelings regarding clients, management, and peers" (a supportive action item: see the complete SFI in Table 1). The respondents were asked to indicate, on a five-point Likert scale, the frequency with which they performed each particular action item in their daily work as supervisors. The scale ranged from "never" (1) to "always" (5).

RESULTS

A factor analysis procedure using varimax rotation was used to determine the factorial distribution of the items of the SFI. The resulting factor structure, which accounts for 64.3% of the common variance, is presented in Table 1. The following seven factors were derived from the factor analysis:

Factor I: Policy modification, planning, and budgeting: 13 items.

This factor relates to the managerial dimension of the administrative function and relates to policy making, planning, budgeting, directing, and regulating.

Factor II: Quality control: 5 items. This factor relates to the superintendency dimension of the administrative function and applies to coordination and control.

Factor III: Contacts with community services: 2 items. This factor relates to working with volunteers, coordinating, and collaborating with services in the community.

Factor IV: Professional skills and techniques: 7 items. This factor relates to improving the professional skills of workers.

Factor V: Professional boundaries: 5 items. This factor relates to workers' ability to set priorities, establish professional identity, and handle ethical problems.

Factor VI: Knowledge and information: 3 items. This factor relates to theoretical knowledge and utilization of sources of information.

Factor VII: Support: 4 items. This factor relates to workers' needs as regards feelings of stress and tension, as well as representation to higher-ups.

TABLE 1

Factor Structure of Supervisory Functions Inventory (SFI) items.

Factors	Action Items	Loadings
<u>Administrative function</u>		
Policy, Planning, & Budgeting	Discussion with workers about plans	
	implemented in the community or in the agency	.56
	Determining training objectives	.56
	Determining policies and work procedures	.72
	Transmitting work procedures to workers	.53
	Applying policies to working plans	.59
	Planning (projects, budget)	.82
	Allocating resources for programs and projects	.84
	Determining workers' job description	.66
	Handling workers' salaries and fringe benefits	.62
	Handling clients' complaints and buffering	
	in emergencies	.52
	Scheduling staff working hours	.46
	Regulating workers' vacations or training	.54
	Staffing (including interviews or	
	submission of assessments of candidates)	.57
Quality Control	Regulating workers' case loads	.57
	Handling disciplinary issues	.54
	Reviewing case records	.80
	Reviewing workers' outputs	.78
	Controlling that assignment are completed on time	.78
Contacts with Community Services	Finding or recruiting volunteers	.68
	Referrals to, and coordination or supervision of private-service providers	.75

TABLE 1 (continued)

Factors	Action Items	Loadings
<u>Educational function</u>		
Professional	Discussing assessment of clients with workers	.81
Skills &	Discussing intervention plans with workers	.86
Techniques	Discussing intervention methods with workers (i.e., casework, group-work)	.80
	Discussing intervention approaches with workers (i.e., crisis intervention, cognitive therapy)	.71
	Discussing intervention techniques with workers (i.e., confrontation, mediation)	.72
	Assisting workers in promoting self-awareness	.46
	Discussing information about clients with workers	.57
Professional	Discussing priorities regarding receiving clients	
Boundaries	with workers	.44
	Discussing ethical issues related to intervention with workers	.57
	Discussing with workers the limits of responsibility	.72
	Discussing professional identity of workers	.44
	Assisting workers in planning their work schedule/time table	.41
Knowledge and	Discussion with workers about their working	
Information	relations with interdisciplinary teams	.63
	Referring workers to information resources in the field/community (e.g., experts, reports)	.56
	Discussing theoretical knowledge with workers (e.g., articles in the field)	.70

Factors	Action Items	Loadings
<u>Supportive function</u>		
	Assisting workers in handling their feelings regarding clients, management, and peers	.62
	Assisting workers by representing their needs to management	.71
	Assisting workers in handling their personal problems	.67
	Assisting workers in handling tensions and frustrations relating to their work in general	.63

Factors I-III can be treated as dimensions of the administrative function; Factors IV-VI as dimensions of the educational function; and Factor VII as representing the supportive function. Cronbach's Alpha reliability coefficients were derived for each of the seven factors: The alpha values are .92, .85, .60, .87, .73, .64, and .76, respectively. Reliability coefficients were also calculated for the three supervisory functions: the reliability alpha values were .94, .90, and .76 for the administrative, educational, and supportive functions, respectively.

Having established the factor structure of the SFI, we next tested its discriminatory power among supervisors from the three types of agencies. Because the three groups of supervisors varied with regard to their educational level (graduate vs. undergraduate degrees) we addressed ourselves to the possibility that the educational level of the research participants had an effect on the SFI. Accordingly, a two-way MANOVA procedure was employed, with educational level and group association as the factor variables, and the dimensions of the SFI as dependent variables. The main effect of the educational level was not significant, nor was the interaction effect between group association and educational level (Wilk's Lambda coefficients for educational level and for the interaction effect were .96 AND .95, respectively). The main effect of group association, however, was significant with Wilk's Lambda .78 (at the MANOVA $F = 4.02$ $p < .001$), indicating that 22% of the variance in the SFI

was explained by group association. We can, therefore, support the discriminatory power of the SFI, while ruling out a possible effect of the educational level of the research participants.

In the second stage we applied univariate analysis of variance to determine what functions within the SFI do discriminate the three groups of supervisors from each other. Table 2 presents the results of these analyses.

As can be seen from Table 2, the only discriminating function is the administrative one. Team leaders report using the administrative function more frequently than do the supervisors from the other groups. Neither the supportive nor the educational functions differentiated among the three groups of supervisors.

DISCUSSION

According to Kadushin (1976; 1985), the administrative, the educational, and the supportive functions inform a generic supervi-

TABLE 2

Univariate comparison of supervisory functions

Supervisory Functions	Team Leaders (TL)	Service Supervisors (SS)	Treatment Supervisors (TS)		Post Hoc Comparison
Administrative	2.92	2.56	2.37	15.04***	TL>TS, SS
(SE=	.07	.11	.08)		
Supportive	3.38	3.31	3.22	0.91 ^{ns}	
(SE=	.06	.13	.07)		
Educational	3.26	3.01	3.28	2.17 ^{ns}	
(SE=	.06	.12	.06)		

*** $p < .001$, ^{ns} not significant

sory model which is applicable to all types of social welfare agencies. A Supervisory Functions Inventory (SFI) is proposed in this study to operationalize this conceptual model. Factor analysis of the SFI yielded seven dimensions corresponding to the administrative, educational, and supportive functions. These results support a factorial structure of the SFI. Corresponding to Austin's (1981) proposition, that supervisors in organizations adhere to their organizational demands, we could expect that team leaders and perhaps service supervisors too, would report using the administrative function more frequently than would do the other supervisors. This proposition was the basis for a further analysis to construct and validate the SFI. The results of the MANOVA show that the SFI has distinguished among supervisors from the different settings, and the ANOVA showed that the administrative function was responsible for this outcome. This finding is in line with Austin's (1981) suggestion that "organizations represent powerful sources of influence upon the behavior of supervisors and workers" (p. 18).

The application of the educational and the supportive functions, however, did not significantly discriminate among the groups. One possible explanation for the failure of the educational and the supportive functions to distinguish among the groups of supervisors is that the SFI is not sufficiently sensitive in this regard. On the other hand, it may be that supervisors regard these functions as so fundamental to their duties that they have assumed a vital status for all social workers, irrespective of the setting.

The firm regard of the educational function seems to reflect a belief that professional knowledge and skills are the *sine qua non* of social supervision. It is also possible that this perception reflects the expectations of the supervisors' workers, who require a common professional guidance. In either case, the basic agreement about the educational tasks reflects a belief in a solid generic professional knowledge, common to all social workers. This conclusion seems to be supported by previous studies that have indicated that supervisors dedicate most of their time to case management (Eisikovits et al., 1983; Shulman, 1982; Parsloe & Stevenson, 1978; Munson, 1981).

In addition to the proposition that the supervisors perceive the supportive function as vitally important to all workers, regardless of

their distinct settings, we further suggest that the supervisors are of the opinion that all social workers are in need of support and backing. This attitude could have resulted from the perception that the job of social workers is associated with high stress. As the literature indicates, there are several sources of such stress. These include, negative attitudes of the community toward welfare services (Cherniss, 1980; Daley, 1979; Maslach, 1982); increasing cuts in the budget of social services accompanied by increased demands for accountability (Austin & Hasenfeld, 1985; Elkin, 1985; Ellis, 1978; Gilbert, 1985; Klepinger, 1978). In addition, administrative requirements were also recognized as a source of workers' strain (Austin, 1981; Kadushin, 1985; Munson, 1983). As Austin has suggested, "at times, supervisors or workers, or both, will find themselves in basic disagreement with such [organizational] rules and procedures" (p. 18). Some authors suggested that this sense of stress results from the perception that administrative requirements are incompatible with professional standards (see Cornwall & Grimes, 1987; Engel, 1970; Kearney & Sinha, 1988; Scott, 1965). Inevitably, these, as well as other possible sources of strain (Cherniss, 1987; Cherniss & Kane, 1987; Pines & Kafry, 1978), generate increased expectations for supervisory support and backing.

All in all, the results of the present study support an initial construct validity of the SFI as an operationalization of the supervisory role. It is capable of discerning the common ground as well as the differences between the performance of supervisors in a wide variety of social welfare agencies. The reader should bear in mind, however, that the present sample was drawn from a single country (i.e., Israel), and that the culture in this country differs from that of the United States. This study did not account for the influence of such differences on supervisors' performance. The practical contributions of the SFI, therefore, should, at this stage, be regarded as tentative and be examined by future research. On the other hand, one could also argue that the fact that Kadushin's conceptual model was established on the grounds of one country's experience, and its operationalization found to be valid in another country, enhances the generalizability of the SFI instrument.

Limitations notwithstanding, we suggest that the empirical validation of Kadushin's theory regarding social work supervision

facilitates methodical, agency-sensitive planning of differential courses and in-service training programs for supervisors. Although a core knowledge base is common to all supervisors, different kinds of supervisors and social workers have different needs determined by the different focuses of their daily work. Finally, the SFI can serve as a basis for a standardized form of supervisory evaluation.

A final remark regarding the use of the SFI. Although one would expect that the SFI be utilized as a single variable, the three supervisory functions, according to Kadushin, comprise distinct content areas. For example, applying a single score in the study of job performance of supervisors in an agency characterized by relatively low educational stress and high administrative stress, would counterbalance these differences. On the other hand, one could use the SFI in a more sensitive manner by looking at its specific dimensions. This could be a useful basis for planning of training, for workers' regard of supervision, and for self-evaluation by the supervisors.

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